

Of VCRs and digital death



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“Accelerated phasing out of technologies that don’t have a high impact on our lives (and the bottom line of businesses that offer them) is the new normal.”

Last month, the news of the “death of VCR” reverberated around the digital world quite profoundly, as its last remaining manufacturer – a Japanese company called Funai Electric – decided to cease production. This had me a bit amused even as I was left with a bittersweet feeling. I remember reading the headlines and wondering if the writers weren’t late by a couple of decades, since the launch of DVDs back in the mid-90s is essentially when the death knell of VHS-VCR first rang out.

For everyone who grew up in the ‘80s and ‘90s, so many of our childhood memories revolve around television sets and especially VCRs, for the freedom they provided from traditional over-the-air television programming. Instead of relying on a broadcaster’s whims and fancies, VCRs allowed us to rent movies and cartoons and watch them whenever we felt like it. I could never have grown up watching the entire Tom and Jerry catalogue before even Cartoon Network launched in India, if it weren’t for VCRs / VHS players. Even Netflix owes its existence to the popularity of VCRs and the concept of movie rentals. If it weren’t for VCRs, I’m pretty sure that all of us non-millennials would miss out on some precious digital moments. Those nondescript black boxes will forever remain an important stepping stone in all of our digital journey.

But the VCR is dead now and nothing’s going to bring it back. The more important question is does anyone care, for better or worse? Most of us have already moved on to different, far better modes of recording and consuming digital media which is a lot more convenient to use than the venerable VCR.

It’s not so much the devices and technologies but how they affect our lives that matters ultimately, of course. We become wistful at the thought of VCR’s death because we had (some may still have) VHS tapes that recorded precious personal moments in time which now may never be revisited. Similarly, we turn nostalgic when we encounter digital relics like a 3.5-inch floppy disk in circa 2016. You’d be hard-pressed to find a brand new PC or laptop that still bundles a floppy drive to try and check if that decades old floppy still works. Now irretrievable, the disk contains the very first digital PC memories you ever created, nevertheless you try to hang on to it as long as you can. It’s human nature.

Accelerated phasing out of technologies that don’t have a high impact on our lives (and the bottom line of businesses that offer them) is the new normal. Similarly, if a technology’s phased out after having a short good run, chances of there being a fast workaround are a lot more now in 2016 than ever before.

For example, in the history of telephones, landlines have lasted for the longest time, followed by cordless phones, non-smart mobile phones and now smartphones – taking the device and its potential far beyond just making and receiving calls. After the death of Google Reader, several equally brilliant RSS readers jumped onto the scene satiating the need of dejected consumers before even their tears ran dry. Hundreds of thousands of gamers played Road Rash on their 16-bit consoles back in the arcade era of gaming, and when one such fan decided to make a 21st century version of the game, thousands of nostalgic gamers (also Road Rash fans, obviously) helped crowdfund the game so that they could take another swing at it. Napster truly democratized file-sharing around the world, much to the RIAA’s chagrin; but despite Napster’s shutting down, file-sharing still continues till this day. Sure it may have become temporarily difficult to find good torrents after the death of Megaupload and (recently) Kickass Torrents, there seems to be no end in sight to filesharing as long as people are willing to share content. Many such examples exist where one technology’s death led to the birth of myriad others.

Technology will never stand still – it will only continue to evolve. Which means we will have to get used to using and dropping technology devices and services through our lifetimes. It’s human to feel a bit sad and nostalgic when your beloved technology fix gets phased out, because anything that creates that sort of an emotional hold has to be something that mattered in your life – things that opened your eyes to a whole new way of doing things. And those are the things that are worth cherishing for as long as you can. 📺

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